

PSYC BC2124 – Personality Psychology Lab
Barnard College, Columbia University · Fall 2026

Class time/location: Tuesday 11:40am-12:55pm, Milstein Center LL002
Instructor: Annie Vu, Ph.D. (she/her/hers)
Email: avu@barnard.edu (please always include “PSYC 2124” in the email header)
Happy (Office) Hours: MW: 1:00pm-2:00pm; T: 1:00pm-3:00pm. I’m happy to meet in person or on Zoom by appointment (request via email or in person).

Prerequisites: PSYC BC1001 Introduction to Psychology; PSYC BC1101 Statistics; PSYC BC1020 Research Methods
Co-requisite: PSYC BC2125 Personality Psychology

About the course and its learning objectives

Course overview

This lab will usually be taken concurrently with BC2125 Personality lecture. It will expand upon some of the theoretical, methodological and analytic issues introduced there, as well as giving you the opportunity to explore topics from within and beyond those covered in the lectures in greater depth through hands-on experience with research design and data analysis.

The semester is broken into 3 projects, each illustrating a common methodological and analytic approach in personality psychology. Projects will be undertaken in small groups; group members will collaborate on design and analysis. Each project will culminate in an in-class group presentation and submission of a brief individual write up of your project.

Course goals

Through these projects, you will gain experience in:

- ☐ Formulating psychological research questions relating to personality
- ☐ Analyzing and visualizing data
- ☐ Interpreting and communicating your findings

Course format

- ☐ This is a lab course that meets once per week.
- ☐ Labs are substantially more interactive and discussion-based than the traditional lecture format and depend on everyone’s active participation in class discussions and activity as well as group work focused on the projects.
 - Your active participation across the semester will therefore contribute a substantial portion of your grade.

Workload

- As a general rule for the amount of time students should expect to commit to classes, the college suggests three hours per week in or outside of class per credit.
 - Since this class is worth 2.5 credits, that corresponds to 7.5 hours per week, split between time in the classroom and time spent completing the associated assignments.

Course requirements and assignments

Participation (10%)

- If you have questions, thoughts, or ideas you want to share, feel free to do so at any time.
 - Keep within the bounds of polite conversation, obviously.
 - Don't interrupt or talk over other people! But do feel free to respond to others without having to raise your hand or wait to be called on.
 - Everyone will get the most out of this lab when the discussion can develop organically and everyone feels free to be part of the conversation when they have something to add.
- **Being part of the in-person discussion is one obvious way to participate, but it's not the only way.**
 - Different people have different styles of participation, and the lab is designed to try and accommodate and encourage different approaches.
 - Your level of engagement with your project partner(s) as you work through your projects is also an important form of participation.
 - You can also participate by coming to office hours.
- At a minimum (i.e. for a passing grade), I'll be looking for some form of participation (loosely defined) from you every week.
 - Higher participation grades will be earned through regular, enthusiastic, productive participation (note that quality is more important than quantity).

Presentations (30%)

- Each project culminates in an in-class group presentation, given on the dates listed in the schedule below.
- It is expected that all group members contribute equally to the presentation preparation and delivery.
 - All group members will receive the same group score, except in exceptional circumstances when it is clear that contributions were not equal.
 - If a group member is unable to present in person on the day of the presentation due to unforeseen circumstances, please notify Prof. Vu. The presentation will be given by the remaining group members, and the absent member may be assigned the group score, assuming equal contributions to the preparation.

Reports (60%)

- Each project also requires a brief individual write up.

- **Written project reports are due one week following the in-class presentation**, i.e. before the next week's lab session — see the schedule below for dates.
- While you will collaborate with group members on the design, analysis, and presentation of research projects, you may not collaborate on the written report.
 - Each group member must write their own individual report.

Grading Policy

Participation (over the course of the semester)	10%
Presentations	30%
Reports	60%

Total	100%
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Grade Assignment

Final grades are determined according to the following boundaries:

97–100%: A+

93–96.9%: A

90–92.9%: A-

87–89.9%: B+

83–86.9%: B

80–82.9%: B-

77–79.9%: C+

73–76.9%: C

70–72.9%: C-

60–69.9%: D

<60%: F

Course support

Academic Accommodations and General Wellness

- It is always important to recognize the different pressures, burdens, and stressors you may be facing, whether personal, emotional, physical, financial, mental, or academic.
 - The faculty and administration recognize this, and are prepared to provide assistance to students in need.
- I encourage you to seek advice from your advisor, Dean, the Center for Accessibility Resources & Disability Services (CARDS), or Barnard Health & Wellness as needed.
 - Please let me know of any issues you wish to share with me that you feel are impacting your ability to complete the course to the best of your ability.
 - Though it isn't always easy, it is better to proactively seek help rather than letting problems build up.

Course Policies

Attendance and Timeliness

- In-person attendance of every lab session is expected, and you should expect to stay for the full duration of the lab.
 - Normally it is departmental policy to remove students who miss more than two lab sessions from the course; however, given ongoing revisions to college-wide health-related policies, exceptions may be made.
 - If you are feeling unwell, you should not come to class, and should notify me of nonattendance before class if possible.
- When you are attending, please arrive on time for class.
 - Frequent lateness will impact your participation grade.

Assignment Late Policy

- Presentations will be given in class on the dates listed in the schedule below.
- Written project reports are due one week following the in-class presentation.
 - **A grade penalty of 5 points will be applied for each day (or part thereof) that an assignment is late**, up to a maximum of 6 days.
 - Work not submitted before the next lab will receive a score of zero.
 - For example, if your work is A+ quality but is submitted a day-and-a-half late, you will only receive a B+.
- This policy is intended to incentivize timely submission while easing the stress of genuine emergencies.
 - When things come up that prevent timely submission you can prioritize accordingly, knowing that a small penalty on one assignment for this lab will not tank your final grade.

Academic Integrity

- Students are expected to follow the Barnard Honor Code, available at <https://barnard.edu/honor-code>.
- You may collaborate with group members on the design, analysis, and presentation of research projects, but you may not collaborate on the written report.

The Use of AI Generative Tools

- Generative AI is an extremely useful tool for many purposes; real researchers are of course using it to help with their research.
- For this class, you are welcome to use AI tools to help with idea generation, help you understand readings, help formulate your ideas for written reports, etc. However, note the emphasis on *helping* rather than doing things for you.
 - Passing someone else's work off as your own is plagiarism and a violation of the honor code, and that includes the work of AI assistants.
 - AI tools can enhance, but should not substitute for, your own efforts.
- Please be aware that it is generally obvious when someone has put little thought of their own into their work.
 - Relying on ChatGPT (or similar) to do most of the work for you will result in bad work (and will accordingly earn you a bad

Course schedule

Date	Session focus	Due
Tue, 9/8	Course overview	
Project 1: t-test		
Tue, 9/15	Project planning	
Tue, 9/22	Data cleaning	
Tue, 9/29	Analysis	
Tue, 10/6	Project 1 presentations (in class)	
Project 2: Correlation		
Tue, 10/13	Project planning	Project 1 report due
Tue, 10/20	Data cleaning & analysis	
Tue, 10/27	Visualization & reporting	
Tue, 11/3	<i>NO CLASS — Election Day, College Closed</i>	
Tue, 11/10	Project 2 presentations (in class)	
Project 3: Regression		
Tue, 11/17	Project planning	Project 2 report due
Tue, 11/24	Data cleaning & analysis	
Tue, 12/1	Visualization & reporting	
Tue, 12/8	Project 3 presentations (in class)	
Tue, 12/15	<i>NO CLASS — reading period</i>	Project 3 report due